

ARAVIND EYE HOSPITAL, *Madurai*

Key people: **Dr Govindappa Venkataswamy,** Founder; **Dr R.D. Ravindran,** Chairman

Year of inception: **1976**

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **Aravind took quality eyecare to rural areas, treating 90 per cent free of cost**
- **Eye camps are central to its work, with 110,000 surgeries in 2025 in over 3,000 camps**
- **These, with 120 vision centres, perform 700,000 surgeries and handle 5-6 million patients**
- **Aurolab, Aravind's manufacturing arm, makes 3.5-4 million intraocular lenses a year at a fraction of global costs**

From the early hours of the morning, the corridors of Aravind Eye Hospital in Madurai are a hive of activity, teeming with patients. Many are elderly, many come from rural areas. They wait patiently for consultations, screenings and surgeries. What began as an 11-bed eye clinic has grown into the nerve centre of the Aravind Eye Care System, a globally recognised institution built around a simple goal: eliminating needless blindness.

Founded in 1976 by Dr Govindappa Venkataswamy—a retired government ophthalmologist known as Dr V—Aravind was born out of both urgency and conviction. "That single vision of eliminating blindness continues to guide everything we do," says Dr R.D. Ravindran, chairman of Aravind Eye Hospital. The hospital emerged from the merger of five private ophthalmology practices run by Dr V and four of his colleagues, who formed a trust dedicated to charitable eye care.

Within a year, Aravind's focus shifted towards community outreach. By 1977, eye camps became central to its work, taking services deep into rural areas. "What began as a small initiative grew rapidly," says Dr Ravindran. "Last year alone, eye camps accounted for around 110,000 surgeries."

Yet the leadership soon realised that camps alone could not offer a solution to rural eyecare. This led to the establishment of vision centres in 2004—permanent, facilities located in rural areas. From a single centre serving about 3,000 people a year, Aravind now operates 120 vision centres across Tamil Nadu and Puducherry, serving roughly 3,500 patients daily. "Over 1.1 million patients were treated in these centres last year," Dr Ravindran notes.

Staffed by trained paramedics and digitally connected to doctors across Aravind's hospitals, the centres ensure that only about 10 per cent of patients need referral for surgery or advanced investigation. "Nearly 80 per cent of our patients receive free treatment, covering a rural population of nearly ten million," he says.

BENEFICIARYSPEAK

"I nearly lost my sight due to an eye ulcer. At Aravind, they performed a surgery and fully cured me. The care I received there was extraordinary"

S. VELLAIAPPAN, *an onion shop owner from Tiruchy*

Supporting this ecosystem is Aurolab, Aravind's manufacturing arm, which produces 3.5–4 million intraocular lenses annually at a fraction of global costs. "Every ten seconds, somewhere in the world, a patient is operated on using an IOL made in Madurai," says Dr Ravindran. Despite handling nearly 20,000 outpatients and up to 3,000 surgeries a day, Aravind maintains one of the lowest infection rates globally. Nearly five decades on, Aravind Eye Hospital stands as proof that scale, compassion and clinical excellence can coexist. And it can transform lives. ■